

MARKY MARK

Every Lie Leaves a Mark

Written by

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Genre: Thriller / Horror

FADE IN:

INT. BILLY'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Billy Rowan, 16, lies on his bed watching television. His bedroom door is closed.

A rustle of wind from an open window stirs the curtains quietly, almost imperceptibly. Billy grips a bowl of popcorn tightly.

A scratching noise electrifies the air. The lights flicker. The television powers off and on. The phone resets.

Suddenly, the room turns frosty. Cold frost forms on the windows.

Billy watches in horror as three marks carve themselves into the wall.

The lights come on.

A PHANTOM stands in the room, looking over him.

Billy looks up in terror. The popcorn falls to the ground.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. BILLY'S BEDROOM - MOMENTS
LATER

Billy's mother appears at the door with a soda.

BILLY'S MOTHER
Billy, I have a soda for you.
Billy? Can I come in?

She opens the door and steps inside.

The room is still. Frost lingers in the air.

Billy is not there.

EXT. DUMPSTER - DAY - ONE WEEK LATER

The local town drunk rummages through a dumpster.

He freezes. Something catches his eye.

Inside – the body of Billy Rowan. Badly decomposed.

His eyes are closed.

TWO BURN MARKS are seared into the skin of his eyelids – like hot irons.

INT. POLICE STATION - NIGHT

The local police sit in tense silence.

The case is too much for them.

After much deliberation, they pick up the phone.

INT. OPP HEADQUARTERS - TORONTO - NIGHT

A phone rings.

The Ontario Provincial Police have been called in.

EXT. HIGHWAY - DAY

A black police cruiser speeds past flat fields and weathered barns, heading north.

INT. CRUISER - MOVING - DAY

DETECTIVE RACHEL CARTER, late 20s, slim build, hair pulled back in a tight bun, drives with one hand on the wheel.

She wears bright lipstick – against regulations – and a guarded expression.

NARRATOR

Detective Rachel Carter had been put on administrative leave – primarily due to inexperience... and for other reasons that would come to light.

EXT. BENTHAM - MAIN STREET - DAY

Rachel's cruiser pulls into a quiet, empty town. A sign reads: "Welcome to Bentham, Ontario - Est. 1847."

NARRATOR

She was appointed lead to investigate the grizzly discovery.

There weren't many places to stay in Bentham.

EXT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - DAY

At the end of the street stands a VICTORIAN MANSE, converted into a motel.

Its painted sign reads: **CASTLE ARMS MOTEL.**

Rachel parks the cruiser on a side street and grabs her overnight bag.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - FRONT DESK - DAY

Red carpet covers the floor. Pictures of dark-age armory line the halls.

Rachel checks in without much conversation.

NARRATOR

She expected to stay for a short while - no more than a few days.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel drops her bag on the bed and removes her coat. The room is quiet, dimly lit.

NARRATOR

She was not an experienced investigator - but made up for it with cocky, big-city attitude.

Rachel stares at herself in the mirror. Her expression softens.

NARRATOR

She kept it quiet, but the scandal that emerged at her precinct in Toronto darkened her mind.

FLASHBACK -

EXT. TORONTO PRECINCT - NIGHT

Quick flashes. GUNFIRE. YELLING. A man's silhouette drops.

NARRATOR

She'd been involved in a shooting that had gone wrong.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel wipes her face, steadying herself.

NARRATOR

She told nobody about him. Nobody knew — or so she thought. She didn't want anybody to know.

INT. BENTHAM POLICE PRECINCT - DAY

Rachel walks through the front entrance of the modest local police station.

BEHIND THE FRONT DESK SITS CHIEF MIKE HEATH — A THIN MAN, WITH EYES THAT RADIATE DISTRUST.

Rachel approaches. She produces a notepad, introduces herself, and offers a handshake.

RACHEL

Detective Rachel Carter. OPP.

Mike reluctantly shakes her hand.

MIKE

I don't think there's anything unusual here. A boy digging around in a dumpster... maybe he fell. Hit his head, perhaps.

Rachel writes in her notebook.

RACHEL

What about his eyes? They were marked.

MIKE

I don't think that mattered at all.

RACHEL

Who was the last person to see him?

MIKE

Some homeless man found his body.

RACHEL

I'd like to see the corpse, if you don't mind.

Mike hesitates, seated at his desk. Rachel stands in front of him, pen still moving across her notepad.

MIKE

He's at our morgue. I'll take you there.

Mike gets up and leads Rachel toward the exit.

CUT TO:

INT. BENTHAM MORGUE - DAY

The CORONER pulls out a drawer and peels back the cloth.

Billy's body lies pale and pasty white.

On each eyelid - a SEARED MARK.

Rachel writes quickly in her notebook.

RACHEL

What could've caused those?

CORONER

Nothing I can think of. Maybe something scratched his eyes... like a cat. But the claws would be too thick.

RACHEL

Can you run tests?

CORONER

I can try. But it'll probably come back inconclusive.

INT. STREET OUTSIDE MORGUE - MOMENTS LATER

Rachel and Mike step out onto the sidewalk.

A few LOCAL MEN sit at a café patio nearby, watching.

LOCAL MAN

It's the town. It's Bentham's reckoning.

Rachel turns toward him, curious.

RACHEL

What do you mean?

LOCAL MAN

You won't find him.

The man turns away, unwilling to say more.

Rachel looks to Mike.

RACHEL
I'm going to interview the mother.
See what she has to say.

MIKE
You won't get anything from her.
She was on the phone that evening.
Said the line went dead for a
while.

CUT TO:

INT. RACHEL'S CRUISER - MOVING - DAY

Rachel drives with one hand, the other holding her phone to her ear.

BOSS (V.O.)
You stay put there, Rachel. I'm
keeping
you on the case until it's solved.

RACHEL
It looks like the boy was into
drugs or something.
Ended up in a bad spot. Probably overdosed
and ended up in the dumpster.

BOSS (V.O.)
You just get that Mike Heath to
work with you. He's got all the
answers somehow locked up in that
town.

Rachel ends the call and tucks her phone away.

EXT. BILLY'S HOUSE - DAY

Rachel pulls up and parks across the street. She steps out of the cruiser and surveys the modest home.

She approaches the front door and knocks.

After a moment, it opens.

ABBY (30S), YOUNG, TIRED, AND VISIBLY
DISTRAUGHT, STANDS IN THE DOORWAY.

RACHEL
I'm sorry for your loss, Mrs...

ABBY
Abigail. But you can call me Abby.

RACHEL
May I come in?

ABBY
Yes.

INT. BILLY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

The kitchen is sparse. A few dishes in the sink. The air is heavy with grief.

ABBY
Billy was a simple child. He loved to play his games in his room alone. I work at the local laundry... evenings, nights. I sleep during the day when he's at school.

RACHEL
Did he have any trouble at school?

ABBY
Not that I'm aware of... no.

RACHEL
Was he taking drugs?

ABBY
Billy would never take drugs. He didn't have any friends at school, but he liked playing in his room. It wasn't unusual for a boy his age.

Rachel flips open her notebook again.

RACHEL
I'd like to see his room.

CUT TO:

INT. BILLY'S BEDROOM - DAY

Abby leads Rachel upstairs.

Rachel scans the room. Her eyes land on the **marks carved into the wall.**

(In jagged, uneven
letters:)
(MORE)

(**"MARKY MARK"**)
(**"CONFESS OR DIE"**)

Rachel steps closer, her expression darkening.

RACHEL
He must've been having some
trouble... Look at the marks on the
wall.

ABBY
They were never there before.
But I've seen Marky Mark elsewhere.

Rachel jots notes in her notebook.

She stops, looks up at Abby, and nods.

RACHEL
Well, if there's anything else you
can think of,
here's my card. Please give me a
call.

She hands over a business card.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
It's long distance... but it's
toll-free.

EXT. BILLY'S HOUSE - DAY

Rachel exits the house, walks to her cruiser, and climbs in.

INT. RACHEL'S CRUISER - DAY

She starts the engine and pulls away, heading toward
downtown.

NARRATOR
She had surmised she'd solved the
case. The boy had obviously been
doing drugs, found himself in the
dumpster, overdosed, and scratched
his eyes in the fall.

Rachel drives, one hand on the wheel.

NARRATOR
She'd write the report and be out
by evening, headed back to Toronto.

But something nags at her.

The name.

Marky Mark.

CUT TO:

INT. BENTHAM POLICE PRECINCT - RECORDS ROOM - DAY

Rachel sits alone at a dusty terminal in the back of the station.

She types: **"Marky Mark Urban Legend"** into the search field.

Old files. Newspaper clippings. Faded black-and-white PHOTOGRAPHS appear on screen.

Each photo shows different crime scenes, decades apart.

Etched in the background - the same words.

(**MARKY MARK.**)
(**CONFESS OR DIE.**)

RACHEL (TO HERSELF)
It's not the first time...

INT. BENTHAM PUBLIC LIBRARY - DAY

Books line the tall wooden shelves.

EMMA, THE LOCAL LIBRARIAN IN HER 60S,
STANDS BEHIND THE DESK.

She flips through a file folder of clippings and notes.

NARRATOR
Emma had heard the stories of the
markings.

Across the room, Rose (30s) chats quietly with ELEANOR
WHITMER, dressed in soft pastels.

ROSE
Can you come?

ELEANOR
No, sorry. I cannot.

Eleanor abruptly ends the conversation and leaves.

Emma looks over, distracted for a moment, then returns her
attention to the folder.

NARRATOR

She had once spoken to Rose about Mark Rooke – the stuff of urban legends. Now he was just Marky Mark – a whisper on the wind. An etching on a wall. A scar carved into wood or stone.

MATCH CUT TO:

An old tree with the name **"MARKY MARK"** carved deep into its bark.

FADE OUT.

INT. BENTHAM PUBLIC LIBRARY - ARCHIVES ROOM - EVENING

Dim light filters through tall windows. Dust particles float in the air.

Rose, early 30s, focused and intellectual, sits surrounded by stacks of old newspapers, reports, and clippings. Her fingers smudge with ink.

NARRATOR

Rose had come from another city and settled into Bentham six months ago. She'd taken the role of head historian at the Bentham Public Library.

She scans another article. Her brow furrows.

NARRATOR

People had come into the library speaking in low tones about the return of the marks.

Rose flips a yellowed newspaper – a headline reads:

(**"MURDER ROCKS BENTHAM - 1973"**)

She circles the corner of the page. In the background – a blurred carving: **MARKY MARK**.

Her curiosity intensifies.

She dives deeper into the pile of records.

Footsteps approach.

EMMA, her assistant, gentle and in her 20s, appears behind her.

EMMA

Rose... it's getting late.

Rose blinks, finally looking up.

ROSE

Yes, I suppose we should be closing
the library now.
I've been so busy with my research,
I've neglected the time.

ROSE (CONT'D)

Thank you, Emma, for your work.

EMMA

You're doing important work too,
Rose.
You're awakening the past.

Rose turns, puzzled.

ROSE

What do you mean?

Emma steps forward, her voice barely above a whisper.

EMMA

It's Bentham's reckoning.

EMMA (CONT'D)

Everybody says it.

Rose stares at her, unsettled.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - RACHEL'S ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel lounges in her room. A tray with room service rests
on the table. A soft knock on the door is followed by the
ring of the motel phone.

She picks it up.

RACHEL

Hello?

MIKE (V.O.)

Hello Rachel, it's Mike Heath
calling.

RACHEL

Yes, Mike.

MIKE (V.O.)
Have you had any dinner?

RACHEL
Don't worry about me. I'm staying
in this evening.
Having something sent up to my
room.

Mike pauses on the other end of the line.

MIKE (V.O.)
Nothing intended by it. I just
don't like to eat alone anymore.
Ever since the wife left me. But
things have been going on.

RACHEL
I don't blame her. There must have
been causes—

MIKE (V.O.)
I was uncertain at the time. I
could see it coming. After the
fact.

RACHEL
My boss tells me you know this town
pretty well.

MIKE
Yeah, I know it pretty well. I know
the people. It's the ones you don't
know that you gotta worry about.

RACHEL
Well, I'm wrapping up my
investigation.
We can discuss it in the morning.

Rachel hangs up.

INT. RACHEL'S BATHROOM - NIGHT

She undresses, turns on the taps, and steps into the shower.
Steam rises. Water rushes.

INT. RACHEL'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Outside the bathroom, the room sits silent.

SCRATCHING SOUNDS begin faintly — dragging across the
surface of a wooden dresser.

Carvings begin to appear:
(**MARKY MARK**)
(**CONFESS OR DIE**)

INT. SHOWER - CONTINUOUS

Rachel tilts her head back, eyes closed under the water.

She pauses.

(Did she hear something?)

She shuts off the water.

INT. BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

She steps out, towel wrapped around her body, and pats her hair dry - **without looking in the mirror.**

A moment of silence.

She hesitates, then lifts her gaze to the mirror.

NARRATOR
She had a crazy feeling of
repentance for the trouble she'd
caused in Toronto... But she
remained stoic, pushing the thought
away.

Rachel stares at her reflection.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - BATHROOM - NIGHT

Rachel stares into the mirror, towel still wrapped around her.

Her reflection stares back.

Then-

THE REFLECTION TILTS ITS HEAD.

Rachel doesn't move.

The light above her flickers once... twice...

Behind her, in the mirror-
(**AN APPARITION APPEARS.**)

SHADOWED. FEATURELESS. **MARKY MARK.**

MARKY MARK (WHISPERING)
Confess your lies... or die.

Rachel gasps and spins around.

Nothing behind her.

INT. RACHEL'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

She stumbles out of the bathroom, breath sharp and erratic.

On the furniture - carved deeply into the wood:

(MARKY MARK)
(CONFESS OR DIE)

Identical to Billy's room.

INT. RACHEL'S ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

She hastily dresses. Her hands shake. She grabs her keys,
shoves them into her coat pocket.

EXT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - NIGHT

Rachel steps out into the quiet street. Cool night air. Her
breath visible.

She walks past dark shops and flickering lamps.

Down the street, a small sign glows dimly:
(THE CROWN TAVERN)

INT. THE CROWN TAVERN - NIGHT

Rachel enters. The place is nearly empty. A few old men sit
at tables in silence.

She sits at the bar.

RACHEL
Whiskey. Neat.

The BARTENDER nods and pours.

No one bothers her. The silence is comforting.

She sips.

And watches herself in the bar mirror.

FADE OUT.

INT. THE CROWN TAVERN - NIGHT

Rachel sits at the bar, nursing her drink.

A stool slides out beside her.

EMMA — college-aged, bright, and curious — takes a seat. She offers a polite smile.

EMMA

So you're the cop from Toronto
who's come to solve this problem we
have?

RACHEL

Bentham has a problem. But it might
just be one person.

EMMA

What do you know?

RACHEL

I heard about the marks on the
wall. Strange history to those
markings in this community.

EMMA

It goes back to the 1800s. I've
been doing some research on local
crime.

RACHEL

I don't know if it's related. Might
just point to the boy having some
psychological problems.

EMMA

Well, I'm not a psychic, but...
psychologically speaking, those
kinds of markings have shown up
for decades.

Rachel turns to her, intrigued now.

RACHEL

I'd like to see your research. I'm
always interested in a new angle —
even if it leads nowhere.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

Is the jail still there?

EMMA

It's abandoned, but yes.

RACHEL
Maybe you can take me there.

EMMA
How about tomorrow?

EMMA (CONT'D)
I'm going to do some more digging
on the stories about Marky Mark.

RACHEL
Yeah. That's a great idea.

They clink glasses softly and sip.

FADE OUT.

INT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - HALLWAY - DAY

A row of lockers under dim lights. School is quiet. Almost empty.

LIAM, a shy, nervous teen, stands at his locker. His hand clutches a pencil.

Suddenly—

AARON LOFTON, big, smug, and cruel, SLAMS Liam into the lockers.

AARON
Let's get this straight, Liam —
you're nobody.
And if you think you're gonna make
waves with my girl,
you've got another thing coming.
You got that?

Liam stays silent. Tight grip on the pencil.

Aaron SNATCHES the pencil and knocks it from his hand. It clatters to the floor.

AARON (CONT'D)
Pick that up, Liam. Right now.

Liam hesitates, then crouches and picks it up. He hands it to Aaron.

Aaron LAUGHS, loud and echoing.

AARON (CONT'D)
You think you can play football?

LIAM
I was gonna try...

AARON
What are you, a crybaby? You gonna
cry your way onto the field?

Aaron walks off down the hallway and disappears.

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Liam remains alone.

The lights above flicker. Shadows stretch across the row of lockers.

SCRAAAAATCH-
A faint, eerie sound. From
somewhere behind him.

On the metal locker beside him, fresh words **begin to carve themselves:**

(**MARKY MARK WAS HERE**)
Liam doesn't notice at first.

His phone BUZZES.

A TEXT from: Emma

"Hey - still good to meet after school?"

Liam stares at the screen, hesitant.

Behind him... the carved words GLOW faintly in the dark.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - HALLWAY - LATER

Liam stands at his locker, typing on his phone.

ON SCREEN:

(**"Nothing's happening.
I'm at the school. I'll
see you soon."**)

He hits send.

His SHADOW looms large on the wall - **larger than himself.**

Liam pulls books out of his locker, distracted, mind racing.

He notices something-

His shadow moves.

Not with him.

He pauses. Frowns.

Turns around.

No one's there.

He returns to his locker... and again -

The shadow moves.

This time, he glances into the **small mirror** taped to the top shelf of his locker.

Behind him... the mirror **begins to frost over.**

His breath catches.

He spins around.

Still nothing.

Then-

A SHARP, TERRIFIED YELL echoes through the empty hallway.

CUT TO:

INT. EMMA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Emma sits at her desk, clutching her phone.

EMMA

I tried calling Liam on my cell phone, but I couldn't get a hold of him.

She speaks to someone offscreen.

EMMA (CONT'D)

I was scared. He should've called me.

VOICE (O.S.)

You've got to go over to the school. See if he's all right.

Emma grabs her coat.

FADE OUT.

EXT. BENTHAM PUBLIC LIBRARY - NIGHT

Emma waits outside, arms crossed against the chill.

Rachel's cruiser pulls up and stops. The passenger door opens.

RACHEL
You know what he looks like. I'll
pick you up and we'll go over to
the high school together.

Emma climbs in. No words. Just tension.

INT./EXT. CRUISER - MOVING - NIGHT

They drive in silence. The streetlights flash across their faces.

The cruiser turns into the lot outside the high school.

EXT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - NIGHT

Rachel and Emma exit the car. The wind blows gently, but the air is cool and biting.

They make their way to the front entrance. Rachel pushes open the door.

INT. HIGH SCHOOL - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Fluorescent lights buzz above. The hallway is still.

Then — Rachel freezes.

A BODY lies on the floor near the lockers.

She rushes over and kneels down.

It's Liam.

She gently turns him over.

His eyes are CLOSED... SEALED SHUT...

Two fresh marks seared into the skin of his eyelids.

Steam rises from them.

Even in death — they **burn**.

Rachel stares in stunned silence.

She lifts his head.

On the lockers nearby, scratched deep into the paint:
(**CONFESS YOUR LIES OR
DIE**)

Emma covers her mouth, trembling.

EMMA
It's Marky Mark. The stories are
true. And Liam...

RACHEL
What do you mean?

Emma looks down at Liam, then back at the message on the
lockers.

EMMA
I've been looking into the urban
legend.

EMMA (CONT'D)
He's come back again. The townsfolk
are right.

EMMA (CONT'D)
He does exist.

Rachel stares down the hallway, heart racing.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Paramedics zip Liam's body into a bag. Police tape is strung
along the lockers. FLASHES from a forensic camera light up
the dim corridor.

Rachel steps back, processing. Emma stands beside her,
shaken.

RACHEL
I'd like to know if anybody knows
anything about this... if there's
someone who can tell us what kind
of person would do this.

Emma pauses, thinking. Then:

EMMA
There's Mrs. Holloway.

EMMA (CONT'D)
She's the oldest woman in town. If
there's any pattern here - legend
or not - she might know it.

Rachel nods.

RACHEL
All right. We're going to see Mrs.
Holloway.

It's only seven o'clock.

EXT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - NIGHT

Police mill around the scene. The AMBULANCE doors swing open and Liam's body is loaded in.

Rachel and Emma exit the school.

They get into the cruiser.

INT. RACHEL'S CRUISER - MOVING - NIGHT

The sirens are off. Just the steady hum of the engine.

Emma rides passenger, directing Rachel through winding side roads.

EMMA
She lives out past the mill, near
the cemetery.

RACHEL
Of course she does.

Emma doesn't laugh.

They drive into the deepening dark.

FADE OUT.

INT. BENTHAM HIGH SCHOOL - BATHROOM - LATE AFTERNOON -
FLASHBACK 4PM

AARON LOFTON stands in front of the mirror.

In his hand: **Liam's pen.**

He stares at his reflection.

He moves slightly.

His reflection does not.

It begins to **distort** - warping unnaturally, as if caught in rippling glass.

Aaron blinks. Rubs his eyes.

Silence.

He looks around the tiled bathroom. Empty.

NARRATOR

It felt as if time had passed –
when none had at all.

INT. COUNTRY ROAD - EVENING

Aaron walks alone, hands in his pockets. The sun is low behind the trees.

He passes an OLD POND. A light wind stirs the grass.

He stops.

Down by the water: a **DOCK** extends out over the pond.

At the far end of the dock – a small **TABLE**.

On it – a **WATCH** glints in the fading light.

Aaron eyes it.

NARRATOR

He decided he was going to steal
the watch.

EXT. DOCK - MOMENTS LATER

Aaron steps onto the dock.

It **CREAKS** loudly underfoot. The wood is old, unmoored,
floating slightly with each step.

He walks slowly, keeping his balance.

SCRAAAAATCH–

He hears it below him – something
scratching beneath the boards.

Aaron stops. Looks down.

On the floorboards in front of him, freshly carved:

CONFESS

He swallows.

Takes another step.

The dock **SHIFTS** hard.

Suddenly — Aaron loses his footing and PLUNGES into the water.

EXT. POND — WATER — CONTINUOUS

He flails — arms splashing wildly.

No one around.

Just water.

And the cold.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. POND — UNDERWATER — EVENING

Aaron sinks.

The weight of his clothes and backpack **pulls him down.**

His limbs kick. Bubbles rise.

But something — **some unseen force** — presses on him.

Crushing his chest. Holding him under.

He drowns.

EXT. DOCK — NIGHT

POLICE LIGHTS flash red and blue across the pond.

Rachel steps carefully along the dock. Each board creaks beneath her.

She reaches the small table at the end.

RACHEL

It's not easy to get out here. No wonder he fell in.

She glances down at the floorboards.

Carved deep:

CONFESS

Rachel frowns.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

That's strange. I wonder when that was put there.

She turns toward the gathering of officers and onlookers.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
Does anybody know about these
markings?

From the back, a voice speaks up.

DOCK OWNER (O.S.)
They were never there before.

Rachel looks back down, brow furrowed.

FADE TO:

EXT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - LATE MORNING

An old stone home. Overgrown garden. Wind chimes clink in the breeze.

Rachel stands at the front door and knocks.

After a long pause - it creaks open.

MRS. HOLLOWAY, mid-80s, sharp eyes, wrapped in a knitted shawl, peers out.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Come in. I've been expecting you.

Rachel hesitates, then steps inside.

CUT TO:

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S KITCHEN - DAY

The kitchen is cozy but aged - the air smells faintly of cinnamon and dust.

Rachel and Mrs. Holloway sit across from one another at a round table.

A pot of tea steams between them. Sunlight pours in through the lace-curtained window.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
It didn't start until 1890.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
Marcus Rooke. They hanged an
innocent man.

Rachel leans in slightly.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
Back then, he was a good fellow.
Gentle.

They accused him of killing his wife... and her lover.

RACHEL
Was he guilty?

MRS. HOLLOWAY
He said he wasn't. Claimed it with
his last breath.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
But the town convicted him. They
made sure of it. He spent 5 years
in prison. Can you imagine?

Rachel frowns.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
Every day that passed, he marked
the walls. A tally for every
morning he woke up behind bars.
When the day came for him to die...

She looks up at Rachel with piercing eyes.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
He said - *"I have counted your
sins... so shall they be counted."*

Rachel slowly writes it down in her notebook.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
13 men died that year.

RACHEL
Who?

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Twelve jurors. And one judge.

Rachel's pen stops mid-sentence.

A long pause.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
That's where it all began.

FADE OUT.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S KITCHEN - LATER

Mrs. Holloway sips her tea, voice low and steady.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Each of those men... horribly
disfigured.

The eyes. Marked.

Rachel listens, notebook now resting on the table.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
Marky Mark wasn't just a legend.
He was a real man.
Wrongfully convicted. Hanged.
If you see two marks...
You have one chance to confess.
Otherwise... it's death for you.

Rachel meets her eyes.

RACHEL
Do you believe what you know?

Mrs. Holloway doesn't answer. Just looks back - firm,
unblinking.

EXT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - AFTERNOON

The sky is darker now. Wind through the trees.

Rachel and Emma step off the porch and head to the cruiser.

EMMA
There's an abandoned prison just
outside town.

It might have records of his existence - Marcus Rooke.

EMMA (CONT'D)
If we go there, we might find
something... something more.

Rachel opens the cruiser door.

RACHEL
I'll take you there tomorrow.

After work.

They get into the car.

The engine starts.

FADE OUT.

INT. BENTHAM PUBLIC LIBRARY - FRONT DESK - DAY

The library is quiet. Sunlight pours through the tall front windows.

Emma sits behind the desk, typing.

The front door swings open.

ELEANOR WHITMORE - late 20s, elegant, and visibly tense - strides in with purpose.

She walks straight to the desk.

Emma glances up.

EMMA

Hi. Can I help you?

ELEANOR

I'd like to check out a book on weddings.

EMMA

Of course. Are you looking for dresses,

bouquets, floral designs...?

ELEANOR

Everything.

Emma begins typing again, searching the catalog.

Eleanor taps her fingers on the desk - slow and deliberate.

ELEANOR (CONT'D)

You're Emma.

EMMA

That's right.

ELEANOR

My fiancé has talked about you.

EMMA

I'm sorry... I don't think we've met?

Eleanor leans forward, voice cold and sharp.

ELEANOR

I would like you to stay away from
my fiancé.
And from my wedding.
If I ever hear from you again –
for anything other than checking
out a book –
there will be a problem.

Emma stares back, stunned.

A long, uncomfortable silence.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. BENTHAM PUBLIC LIBRARY - FRONT DESK - CONTINUOUS

Emma's jaw drops slightly, caught off-guard.

Still, she gathers herself. Speaks with calm poise.

EMMA

If I've done anything to offend
you...
I'm very sorry.
I don't even know your boyfriend's
name.

Eleanor stares hard at her.

ELEANOR

You'll know when he's married to
me.

ELEANOR (CONT'D)

Our marriage will be legal.
Daddy's a judge. He'll be marrying
us.

She turns sharply and walks out – leaving without the book.

The bell above the door jingles behind her.

Emma watches her go.

It's clear now – **this wasn't about a book.**

It was a warning.

Emma exhales, shaken but composed.

FADE OUT.

INT. COURTHOUSE - COURTROOM - DAY

A gavel slams.

JUDGE WHITMORE (O.S.)
I find the defendant guilty as
charged.

JUDGE WHITMORE - 60S, STERN,
COMMANDING, AND COLD-EYED - SITS AT
THE BENCH, UNMOVED. THE GAVEL RESTS IN
HIS HAND LIKE A WEAPON.

The defendant, a gaunt man in his 30s, stands silently at
the defense table, his head down.

A POLICE ATTENDANT moves forward, cuffs him, and begins
escorting him out.

Murmurs ripple through the gallery.

Two MEN in the back row lean toward each other.

MAN #1 (WHISPERS)
This should've been a slam dunk.

MAN #2
It couldn't have been him.
Everybody knew it was somebody
else.

The convicted man is led out through the side door.

Judge Whitmore watches, expression unreadable.

NARRATOR
Eleanor badgered everybody.
Even her husband-to-be - a weak-
willed man marrying her for her
father's money. Not hers. The
judge's. Judge Whitmore was a
corrupt man. He moved through
proceedings under the rule of law
-but when it came to the town's
understanding of justice... he took
matters into his own hands.

The courtroom settles. The gavel taps again.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Dim light. A low hum from the neon sign outside flickers through the curtain.

JUDGE WHITMORE sits on the edge of the bed in a T-shirt and boxers, sipping from a glass of whiskey.

A PROSTITUTE - mid-30s, sharp but tired - is buttoning up her blouse, preparing to leave.

Whitmore leans forward, pulls his pants from the nearby chair, and takes out his wallet.

He peels off some bills and hands them to her.

PROSTITUTE

You don't have any problem with me asking for a little bit more than just the money, do you, Judge?

He raises an eyebrow.

JUDGE WHITMORE

Just a minute, honey. How do you know I'd have anything else to offer?

PROSTITUTE

The other ladies talk a lot.

Whitmore smirks, leans back.

JUDGE WHITMORE

Well, I'm not your- you're not...
You're not on the payola.
My daddy did it.
My granddaddy did it.
And my great-granddaddy did it.

He sips his drink, unapologetic.

The woman doesn't respond - just picks up her purse and heads for the door.

The Judge sits in the glow of the motel light, completely at ease.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Judge Whitmore opens the door, holding it for the prostitute.

JUDGE WHITMORE
Have a good night.

He **ushers her out** with subtle force — just enough to keep her from asking anything else.

The door shuts. He turns back toward the bed.

Whitmore sits, pulls out his wallet, and begins **counting money**.

The PHONE RINGS. He answers without hesitation.

JUDGE WHITMORE (INTO PHONE)
Yeah. Take it out of lockup. We
won't miss it.

He hangs up.

A **slight breeze** rustles the curtains. An open window sways slightly.

INT. MOTEL BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The Judge stands in front of a **full-length mirror**. He adjusts his shirt collar.

Then he freezes.

On his **forehead**, a **MARK appears** — burned into the skin.

JUDGE WHITMORE
What the—?

He backs away. Then hurries out.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Whitmore opens his shaving kit on the nightstand. Fumbles through it.

He pulls something out — we don't see what yet.

INT. MOTEL BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

Back in front of the mirror, he stares—

THE IMAGE SHIFTS.
Inside the mirror now: **MARKY MARK.**

Shadowed. Hollow-eyed. Face unreadable.

The Judge freezes, paralyzed.

Suddenly — **Marky Mark** steps **THROUGH** the mirror.

He raises a **gun**.

Shoves the barrel **into the Judge's** mouth.

BLAM!

Blood sprays the mirror.

The Judge collapses, **choking and gurgling**.

As he hits the ground, **three glowing marks** appear on his chest —

burned into the skin.

He goes still.

Dead.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

CHIEF MIKE HEATH kneels beside Judge Whitmore's lifeless body.

The room is dim. The mirror is **cracked and blood-splattered**.

He rifles through the Judge's pockets — slow, deliberate.

A CLEANING LADY stands in the doorway, shaken.

CLEANING LADY

I just... I just found him like this.

CHIEF HEATH

You did the right thing. Thank you.

She nods and steps back, leaving him alone.

Moments later, Rachel enters the room. She looks over the scene.

RACHEL

This isn't natural.

CHIEF HEATH

It's obviously natural causes.

Rachel raises an eyebrow.

RACHEL
What do you mean?

CHIEF HEATH
Has the same problem all the others
had - the marks.

RACHEL
No. This has every aspect of
something out of the ordinary.

Chief Heath straightens up - firm, dismissive.

CHIEF HEATH
Nothing about this is unusual.

Rachel watches him, unconvinced.

FADE TO:

INT. BENTHAM POLICE STATION - MIKE HEATH'S OFFICE - NEXT DAY

Rachel storms into Mike's cluttered office. He's behind his
desk with coffee and paperwork.

RACHEL
Okay, Mike - what is going on?

RACHEL (CONT'D)
There's a pattern here. All these
deaths...
they're not isolated.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
Are we dealing with a serial
killer?

Mike leans back in his chair. Silent.

Rachel stares him down.

CUT TO BLACK.
INT. BENTHAM POLICE STATION - MIKE
HEATH'S OFFICE - DAY

Chief Heath stands, walks slowly around his desk toward
Rachel.

CHIEF HEATH
There may be a pattern.
I've been working that angle.
Charles Taylor may have been one of
them.

(MORE)

CHIEF HEATH (CONT'D)
There've been several deaths before
that, too.

Rachel studies him — unsure whether to believe him or not.

CUT TO:

EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DAY

Rachel drives alone in her cruiser, the tires humming on asphalt.

The windows are down slightly. Wind plays with a few loose papers on her passenger seat.

Her face is tense — haunted.

NARRATOR
Her mind was heavy with the thought
of Marky Mark.

She slows the car.

EXT. FENCE LINE - MOMENTS LATER

She pulls over beside a weathered wooden fence.

Painted in jagged black letters:

MARKY MARK
(MARKY MARK WAS HERE)

CONFESS OR DIE
She steps out of the vehicle,
stares at the markings.

NARRATOR
She had been talking to people. But
no one was willing to give up
information. It was like the whole
town had agreed — to keep the truth
buried.

Rachel runs her fingers along the carved letters, her breath shallow.

NARRATOR
If Marky Mark was real — he wasn't
just a ghost. He was a reckoner.

EXT. BACK IN THE CRUISER - DRIVING - LATER

Rachel continues down the road.

More fences. More signs. More **markings**.

She glances from side to side.

The repetition is **oppressive**. Strategic.

NARRATOR

The marks didn't feel random. They
were tracking something. Or
someone.

EXT. END OF THE ROAD - DUSK

At the end of the road — standing in the fading light —

A **PHANTOM IMAGE**.

Still. Black. Almost human.

Rachel SLAMS the brakes.

Her body jerks forward.

She looks again.

Nothing there.

Just the road... and the quiet.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DUSK

Rachel drives, eyes darting side to side.

Then she sees it.

At the end of the road, emerging from the mist—

A **GHOSTLY FIGURE**.

Not fully human. Not fully spirit.

Its presence is **unsettling** — as if it exists in a space
between reality and judgment.

Rachel's foot eases off the gas. The car slows.

She stares.

The figure stands motionless.

Its **skin translucent**, waxlike — stretched taut over **skeletal bone**.

Along its arms and chest, **faint glowing marks** pulse softly —

each one a soul judged.

Eyes: hollow voids, flickering like dying embers.

Mouth: sewn shut with jagged, black stitches.

NARRATOR

Only the guilty speak.

He listens.

It wears a long, tattered **frock coat** – something between a **Victorian undertaker** and an **executioner**.

Ink-stained gloves cover its hands.

Heavy boots, caked with dirt, rest on the edge of the pavement –

as if it had walked from **one world into another**.

Rachel stares.

Staring **into oblivion**.

The car rolls to a near stop.

She slips the gear into PARK.

And just like that–

The figure vanishes.

Gone. No trace.

INT. RACHEL'S CAR - MOMENTS LATER

Rachel sits frozen behind the wheel.

Breathing shallow.

CUT TO:

BLACK.

EXT. BENTHAM LIBRARY - DUSK

Rachel's cruiser pulls up slowly in front of the library.

Emma waits on the steps.

Rachel rolls down the window.

RACHEL
I think I saw him.

EMMA
Who?

RACHEL
You know... Marky Mark.

Emma's eyes widen but she nods.

EMMA
Before we head to the jail, I want
to speak with Rose.
She's the chief historian for the
town.
If anyone knows about the curse -
it's her.

Rachel gets out of the car. They head inside.

INT. BENTHAM LIBRARY - DOWNSTAIRS STACKS - NIGHT

Dim light. Dusty shelves. The air is dry, still.

Rose, 60s, focused and quietly intense, leads them through
the narrow aisles.

EMMA
Rachel, this is Rose.
Rose - Rachel.

Rose nods politely. She pulls out a thin, aged **booklet** from
a locked case, then spreads it on a reading table.

The pages are yellowed, the ink faded.

ROSE
These were collected notes.
From a man who claimed he was
cursed.
She opens to a marked page.

ROSE (CONT'D)
*"The mark's faded. But only after I
spoke the truth."*

Rachel leans in, reading over her shoulder.

RACHEL
So what... he confessed something,
and the curse disappeared?

Emma shrugs, unsure.

EMMA

Or he just thought it did.

EMMA (CONT'D)

Either way... nobody else survived.

A beat of silence.

They all stare at the page.

FADE OUT.

EXT. ABANDONED JAIL - NIGHT

Rachel's cruiser pulls up to a crumbling stone building at the edge of town.

The **abandoned jail** sits quiet, lost in time. Overgrown grass. Rusted fencing.

INT. ABANDONED JAIL - MAIN HALL - NIGHT

Rachel and Emma step inside, flashlights in hand.

The beam of light cuts through thick dust.

Mattresses lie scattered.

Empty cells.

Peeling, blistered paint.

They move slowly.

INT. CELL BLOCK - MOMENTS LATER

Emma stops in front of a rusted iron door.

EMMA

This is it. His cell.

RACHEL

Marcus Rooke.

INT. ROOKE'S CELL - CONTINUOUS

The cell is small and quiet.

On every wall - **tally marks**, grouped in fives.

Hundreds. Maybe thousands.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

This must be his.

EMMA
Obviously...

He was marking the days.

The years.

Rachel kneels beside the broken cot.

Something's wedged underneath.

She reaches down and **pulls out an old book** – worn, wrapped in brittle cloth.

RACHEL
This might shed some light...

She opens it gently.

On the inside cover – an **inscription**.

But it's not Marcus Rooke's name.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
This isn't him...

EMMA
What?

Rachel flips the page, then begins to read aloud.

FADE TO:

INT. ROOK'S CELL - NIGHT

Rachel holds the brittle journal in her hands.

She reads aloud, her voice low, almost reverent.

RACHEL (READING)
"On 25 May 1897, three years after
Marc had died,
I found my redemption.
I was able to save my life from the
terrible judgment
that Marky Mark had placed upon me.
I realize now that I had sinned –
and if I didn't make
a public confession, I would never
live. I am grateful to this day,
and therefore have left this
journal as a testimonial to my
reconciliation."

She stops.

The cell feels colder.

Rachel slowly sets the journal down on the cot.

Her eyes are wide. Her breath shallow.

NARRATOR

Now she knew the unspeakable terror
held in store for anyone who
received a mark.

A FLASH of her hotel room -

The carved messages on the furniture.

Rachel's expression tightens with dread.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)

It raised the specter...

that the marks she'd seen were not just warnings -
but a premonition.

Back in the cell, Emma watches her closely.

Rachel's face is pale.

Fear etched across it.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. ROOK'S CELL - NIGHT

Rachel stares at the journal, its final lines still echoing
in her head.

The dim light from Emma's flashlight flickers.

NARRATOR

The stories weren't just myths
whispered through generations -

They were warnings.

And every piece of evidence pointed to one terrifying truth:

Marky Mark wasn't just a symbol of judgment...

He was a force.

And he was hunting the guilty.

Rachel's hands tremble slightly. She exhales.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)

The marks had appeared in her room.

She wasn't just an investigator anymore...

She was a target.

Emma leans in behind her, reading over her shoulder. Her voice is almost a whisper.

EMMA

If this diary is real... then
someone survived.
That means there's a way out.

Rachel slowly looks up at her.

Her face pale. Her eyes dark.

RACHEL

A way out... for those who confess.
But what if...
What if you don't even know what
you're guilty of?

Silence.

Only the sound of dust settling in the dead air of the cell.

Emma doesn't answer.

Neither of them knows what's coming next.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. ROOK'S CELL - NIGHT

The question hangs in the air - unanswered.

Emma looks down at the floor, her voice soft.

EMMA

Maybe... maybe it's not about
knowing.
Maybe it's about owning up to what
you're hiding.
Even if you've buried it deep.

Rachel stares at the journal for a moment.

Then she closes it and **shoves it into her coat pocket.**

RACHEL

Then we need to find someone who
knows more about this.
Someone who might have an answer
before I—
Before anyone else ends up like
Billy or Liam.

Emma nods.

EMMA

Then we go back to Mrs. Holloway.
She's the only one left who
remembers the old stories.

EXT. BENTHAM - NIGHT

The cruiser rolls slowly through the quiet streets.

Bentham is eerily still.

Storefronts are dark.

Curtains twitch.

Porch lights flicker.

NARRATOR

The town had the eerie stillness of
a place that knew something dark
was moving through it.

Rachel glances at shadowy windows.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)

The deeper she dug...The more alone
she felt.

INT. CRUISER - MOVING - NIGHT

Rachel grips the steering wheel. Emma stares straight ahead.

No one speaks.

The town watches.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Rachel and Emma step onto the porch. The house is dark,
lifeless.

Rachel knocks.

Nothing.

She knocks again – louder.

After a long moment, a faint **click** of the door.

It opens just a crack.

MRS. HOLLOWAY peers through – only one eye visible.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
You shouldn't be here.

RACHEL
Mrs. Holloway, we found something.

A diary. Someone survived the mark.

We need to know how.

Mrs. Holloway's face hardens.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
It doesn't matter.

Rachel steps closer. Urgent.

RACHEL
It matters to me.
I think I've been marked.

A long pause.

Mrs. Holloway's eyes flicker to Rachel's hands.

Her expression shifts – subtle but telling. Something unreadable moves behind her eyes.

Finally, she opens the door wider.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Come inside.

Rachel and Emma exchange a glance.

Then step over the threshold.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

The door clicks shut behind them.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

The door closes behind them.

Rachel and Emma follow Mrs. Holloway through the darkened hall. The air is thick.

NARRATOR

The house smelled like old books
and cinnamon...

But beneath it, something musty.

Like time itself had settled into the walls.

INT. KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

Mrs. Holloway eases into a creaky chair at the table. She exhales.

MRS. HOLLOWAY

I warned you before, Detective.

Bentham's reckoning isn't something you can solve
like a normal case.

Rachel steps forward and sets the **diary** on the table.

RACHEL

This man confessed. And he
survived.
What did he do?
How did he make it stop?

Mrs. Holloway hesitates. Her hand hovers, then gently
touches the leather cover.

MRS. HOLLOWAY

Confession must be public.
It must be true.
And most importantly...
It must be witnessed.

Rachel's stomach clenches. She leans in.

RACHEL

Witnessed? By who?

Mrs. Holloway meets her eyes, dead serious.

MRS. HOLLOWAY

By Marky Mark.

A chill hits Rachel like a blade of ice.

RACHEL
You mean—he has to be there?
While you confess?

Mrs. Holloway nods.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
If the marks have appeared...
It means judgment is coming.
He gives one chance. A single
opportunity to atone.
But you can't run.
And you can't hide.

Rachel grips the table edge, knuckles white.

Silence.

Then—

EMMA (SOFTLY)
But what if...
What if someone doesn't confess?
Or if they don't know what they
did?

Mrs. Holloway's face darkens. She looks away.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Then there's only one outcome.

The room feels tighter.

The air — heavier.

Rachel swallows hard.

RACHEL
Then I guess...
I need to figure out what I've
done.
Before it's too late.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - RACHEL'S ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel sits at the edge of her bed, staring at the
furniture.

The marks are still there.

Cut deep into the wood.

MARKY MARK
(CONFESS OR DIE)

She hasn't touched them.

They haven't faded.

NARRATOR
That meant her time was running
out.

Rachel picks up her phone. Her thumb hovers over her boss's
contact.

But she doesn't press call.

NARRATOR
What would she even say?
That she was being haunted by a
vengeful spirit?
That she might have to confess
something
she hadn't even admitted to
herself?

She puts the phone down.

Runs her fingers through damp hair.

INT. BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

The mirror is still fogged from her earlier shower.

She walks past it, pauses—

Words appear in the condensation.

Two words.

TOMORROW. MIDNIGHT.
Rachel freezes.

A chill runs down her spine.

NARRATOR
Marky Mark was coming. And she had
less than 24 hours to figure out
her sin.

CUT TO:

INT. RACHEL'S ROOM - LATER THAT NIGHT

Rachel lies in bed, eyes open.

She doesn't sleep.

She doesn't blink.

Her breath is shallow.

WHISPERS echo faintly in the room.

Not words.

Soft. Measured. Counting.

Rachel pulls the blankets tighter around herself.

Her eyes flick to the mirror.

It's clear now.

But something watches from just beyond reflection.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - RACHEL'S ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel lies in bed, gripping the sheets like an anchor.

The **bedside lamp** glows softly - her last defense against the dark.

The room is too quiet.

Every creak of the old building sends a fresh pulse of unease through her body.

NARRATOR

What had she done? She had made
arrests. Fought to do her job
right. But had she crossed a line?

She stares at the ceiling.

NARRATOR

Confession must be public. It must
be true. And it must be witnessed.

Rachel turns, eyes wide open in the dim light.

NARRATOR

This wasn't just about guilt. It
was about justice. Real justice.
(MORE)

NARRATOR (CONT'D)
The kind the system couldn't
manipulate. The full truth.

She sits up, rubbing her face, palms pressed hard into her eyes.

The digital clock beside her glows:

3:12 AM

NARRATOR
Tomorrow at midnight.
That's when he would come.

Her breath catches in her throat.

She grabs her phone and begins to type:

TEXT - RACHEL:
*Meet me first thing in the morning.
We're going to the archives. I need
to know exactly what happened to
Marky Mark.*

A moment later — the screen lights up.

TEXT - EMMA:
*Okay. But... I don't think this is
something we can stop.*

Rachel exhales.

RACHEL (SOFTLY)
We'll see.

She puts the phone down and stares into the quiet.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - NIGHT

Rachel glances toward the bathroom mirror.

The condensation is gone.

But her **reflection remains** — still. Silent.

Then—

A slow fog creeps back across the glass.

A faint breath.

But it isn't hers.

CUT TO:

EXT. BENTHAM HISTORICAL ARCHIVE - MORNING

A squat, forgotten building tucked between a closed-down bakery and a pawnshop.

Faded letters above the door barely read: **BENTHAM HISTORICAL SOCIETY**

INT. ARCHIVE - CONTINUOUS

Dust clings to every surface.

The scent of aged paper hangs in the still air.

Rachel and Emma stand in front of a sagging wooden **filing cabinet**.

Emma opens a drawer, pulls out a brittle folder.

EMMA

"Rooke, Marcus - 1888."

Rachel takes it carefully, flipping through yellowed pages.

RACHEL

Marcus Rooke - nicknamed Marky Mark. A quiet, unassuming man. A bookkeeper. Lived alone. Paid his taxes. Kept to himself.

Emma reads over her shoulder.

EMMA

They said he killed a judge's son. But look...

She points to the bottom of the page.

EMMA (CONT'D)

The evidence was flimsy.
A witness statement was changed at the last minute.
And the judge ordered the execution two days later.

Rachel's pulse quickens.

RACHEL

A rush to judgment...

Emma turns the page.

She gasps softly.

A **grainy photograph** – Marcus Rooke on the gallows.

His face is **covered in tally marks**.

Rachel reads the caption beneath it.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

"Before his death, Marcus Rooke was
branded by the people of Bentham –
each mark representing a sin the
town believed he had committed."

EMMA

Branded... Not just executed.
Marked.

She flips another page.

EMMA (CONT'D)

Here... his final words.

Rachel reads aloud from the fragile handwriting.

RACHEL

"You counted my sins.
Now they shall be counted against
you."

A heavy silence settles between them.

Emma looks down, voice quiet.

EMMA

He wasn't guilty. They were.

Rachel stares at the page. Her voice nearly breaks.

RACHEL

And now... So are we.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. ARCHIVE ROOM - DAY

The silence hangs heavy. Dust particles swirl in the light.

NARRATOR

The room suddenly felt smaller.

The weight of history pressing in.

Rachel stares ahead, her face pale.

She reaches for her phone and types.

TEXT - RACHEL:

**There's just one last proof of evidence that would lead me to believe these deaths haven't been random... and that Marky Mark has come back from the dead to exact revenge on people who lie.* We need to go to the cemetery. Can you find where his plot is?*

A moment later, her phone buzzes.

TEXT - MIKE:

Yes. I can get that. I'm not finished until 8 o'clock tonight, but you can go if you've got a flashlight.

TEXT - RACHEL:

Yes, that would be fine. The sun will be up for a while.

EXT. LIBRARY PARKING LOT - 8:00 PM

Rachel pulls up in her cruiser. Emma walks out and climbs in.

EMMA

What's next?

RACHEL

If there really was a Marky Mark—
If he's buried, we can at least confirm when he died. Maybe understand the force behind this. No one seems to know anything. Or they're too afraid to say.

EXT. BENTHAM CEMETERY - NIGHT

The cruiser pulls through a rusted **gabled gate** with iron letters:

BENTHAM CEMETERY

Rachel parks. She and Emma step out with flashlights in hand.

They walk quietly between worn headstones.

The light fades. Crickets echo.

They move into the **old section** of the cemetery.

Finally, Emma stops.

EMMA

There.

She shines her light on an old, moss-covered stone.

MARCUS ROOKE

Executed 1888

"Judged by Man. Awaited by God."

Emma pulls something from her coat pocket.

A simple wooden **cross**.

EMMA (CONT'D)

I brought this.

Maybe we can say some words.

Rachel stares at the grave. Silent.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. BENTHAM CEMETERY - NIGHT

The light is nearly gone.

A wind rises, weaving through the gravestones.

NARRATOR

It was getting dark.

Emma looks around and spots a small public **restroom facility** tucked near the edge of the cemetery.

EMMA

I'll be quick.

She heads off.

INT. CEMETERY WASHROOM - NIGHT

Emma pushes open the creaky door.

The air inside is damp and stale.

She finishes quickly, then moves to the sink and **washes her hands**.

The faucet runs.

She glances up—

Her reflection is frozen.

Her hands move in real time, but the **mirror version of her does not.**

Behind her image—

MARKY MARK APPEARS.

In the reflection of his **burning eyes— a glimpse of hell.**

Flames. Screams. Agony.

WHISPER (O.S.)

Confess your lies...

Emma GASPS and stumbles backward.

Marky Mark **emerges from the mirror**, stepping forward, soundless.

Emma SCREAMS, shoving the door open—

EXT. BENTHAM CEMETERY - NIGHT

Rachel turns—hearing nothing yet—just wind through trees.

Suddenly—

Emma bursts from the dark, sprinting toward the cruiser.

EMMA

Rachel! GO!

Rachel jumps into the driver's seat.

She fumbles with the keys. **The engine won't turn.**

Emma dives into the passenger seat, panting.

Rachel looks up.

Marky Mark stands in front of the cruiser.

Still.

Watching.

All the lights fade.

The interior light.

The dashboard.

Even the moonlight seems to vanish.

Rachel kills the headlights. Total darkness.

A beat.

The ignition CLICKS—then ROARS TO LIFE.

Rachel SLAMS the gas. The cruiser tears out of the cemetery, tires skidding on gravel.

EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - CONTINUOUS

The cruiser speeds into the night.

Only darkness in the rearview mirror.

INT. RACHEL'S CRUISER - MOVING - NIGHT

Both women are breathless. Pale.

EMMA

He was there...

Rachel nods, eyes locked on the road.

RACHEL

I know.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

We've got less than four hours.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Rachel and Emma step inside.

Mrs. Holloway is already standing in the doorway, waiting.

She didn't blink when they knocked.

MRS. HOLLOWAY

You read the files.

(Not a question.)

Rachel nods.

RACHEL

It wasn't just an execution. It was a cover-up.

Mrs. Holloway gestures for them to sit.

The living room is dimly lit. Still. Heavy with silence.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
They thought it would end there.
They thought they could bury their
sins with him.

Emma leans forward, frowning.

EMMA
But it didn't.

Mrs. Holloway stares toward the window. Her voice is soft.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
No. The first man marked was the
judge himself. Then the sheriff.
Then the witnesses. One by one...
they were counted.

Rachel swallows hard.

RACHEL
And since then?

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Every few decades, it happens
again. The town buries its sins.
But Marky Mark...
he doesn't forget.

Silence.

Rachel shifts in her seat, uneasy.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (CONT'D)
This time...
It's you.

Rachel clenches her jaw.

RACHEL
Why?
Why now?

Mrs. Holloway's voice drops — grave and steady.

MRS. HOLLOWAY
Because you buried something too,
Detective.

Rachel freezes.

The air in the room seems thinner.

More fragile.

Emma turns, voice trembling.

EMMA

Rachel...

What did you do?

Rachel's hands tighten into fists.

Her heartbeat THUDS in her chest.

She opens her mouth—

CLICK.

All the lights go out.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Darkness.

Only their breathing.

And the echo of something moving through the house.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Darkness.

Total.

Rachel's breath catches.

She fumbles at her side—reaching for her gun—

VOICE (O.S.)

You see it now.

It's not Mrs. Holloway.

The voice is close.

Too close.

A whisper that somehow fills the room.

A cold breeze presses against the back of Rachel's neck.

She turns—

Across the room, a mirror begins to glow faintly.

In the glass:

**THREE TALLY MARKS BURNED INTO HER
SKIN.**

A foggy breath appears on the
mirror's surface.

Not hers.

Rachel's chest rises sharply.

She stumbles back, knocking into the table.

RACHEL

Emma—

But Emma is frozen.

Eyes wide.

Locked on something **behind Rachel.**

Rachel turns.

She sees—

Him.

Tall. Gaunt. Silent.

A faceless figure shrouded in shadows, **covered in tally
marks.**

The black stitches across his mouth **twitch.**

Then—

He raises a hand.

Rachel freezes.

Her body locks. Her breath stops.

The world **drops away.**

EXT. THE VOID - UNKNOWN

Rachel floats in nothingness.

Cold. Silent. Weightless.

A voice in the dark—

MARKY MARK (V.O.)
Confess.

A pause.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)
Or be counted.

INT. VOID - RACHEL

Rachel shakes. Her lips part. Her breath falters.

NARRATOR
She had one chance.

One moment.

What had she buried?

A secret rises—

Ugly. Heavy. Bitter.

The **final mark burns** across her skin, hot and searing.

She cries out.

NARRATOR (CONT'D)
She had to speak—

Or disappear into the darkness forever.

BLACK. SILENCE.

FADE TO:

INT. THE VOID - UNKNOWN

Rachel kneels in darkness.

Her **throat burns**. Her **pulse hammers** in her ears.

The blackness stretches endlessly in every direction—
swallowing light, sound, time.

In front of her: **Marky Mark**.

Still. Motionless. Waiting.

The three tally marks glow on her arms.

Each one hotter now — searing deep.

NARRATOR

They weren't just symbols.

They were counting down.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)

Confess.

The whisper scrapes the inside of her mind.

Rachel's eyes squeeze shut. She shakes.

A memory rises.

INT. DARK ALLEY - TORONTO - FLASHBACK - NIGHT

Cold. Wet pavement.

A young man—barely more than a boy—**runs down the alley.**

Rachel chases, gun raised, breath ragged.

NARRATOR

He had no tool. No real threat.

Just fear.

(BANG.)

The shot echoes.

The boy hits the ground.

Rachel stands over him, wide-eyed.

INT. TORONTO PRECINCT - FLASHBACK - NIGHT

Rachel stands before superiors.

RACHEL (V.O.)

He had a weapon.

Nods. Papers signed.

NARRATOR

The city covered for her. The
department called it a
"misunderstanding."

INT. THE VOID - RETURN

Rachel kneels. Trembling.

NARRATOR

She never spoke about it again.
Until now.

Marky Mark tilts his head. Waiting.

Rachel gasps for air.

The truth coils in her chest like fire.

She opens her mouth—then clamps it shut again.

She fights.

Losing.

The void begins to constrict.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)

Confess.

Rachel screams.

RACHEL

I LIED!

She collapses.

RACHEL (CONT'D)

I shot an innocent kid.

I covered it up.

I told myself it wasn't my fault...

but it was.

It was.

Silence.

She gasps for air, sobbing.

The **tally marks** **fade** from her skin.

She looks down — the burns remain, but the **marks are gone**.

Cracks form in the darkness — like glass shattering in slow motion.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)

Judgment given.

Judgment passed.

The blackness fractures—

INT. MRS. HOLLOWAY'S LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel GASPS.

She clutches her chest, sprawling on the floor, drenched in sweat.

Her heartbeat thunders in her ears.

EMMA kneels over her, panicked.

EMMA

Rachel? Rachel, are you—

Rachel slowly sits up, trembling.

She looks at her arms.

No marks.

She exhales, shuddering.

MRS. HOLLOWAY (O.S.)

You confessed.

Rachel nods, voice hoarse.

RACHEL

I... I did.

Emma watches her, pale and shaken.

EMMA

Then... it's over?

Rachel looks past them.

Across the room—a **mirror**.

Her reflection stares back.

Still.

Too still.

NARRATOR

Deep down, she knew— Marky Mark was not gone. He had only judged her. The town still had secrets. Others still carried sins they refused to admit.

Mrs. Holloway speaks softly, almost to herself.

MRS. HOLLOWAY

You survived.

But someone else will be counted next.

Rachel's fists clench.

She stands.

NARRATOR

She had faced her judgment. But the town? The town was still burying its sins.

EXT. BENTHAM - NIGHT

A cold wind moves through empty streets.

Porch lights flicker.

Curtains twitch.

Bentham sleeps.

But the counting continues.

NARRATOR

And Marky Mark was still counting.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Rachel wakes with a gasp, drenched in sweat.

The lamp beside her flickers back on.

She sits up.

Breathing.

Alive.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. CASTLE ARMS MOTEL - RACHEL'S ROOM - MORNING

Sunlight creeps through the curtains.

Rachel zips up a **duffel bag**.

She pauses. Looks around.

NARRATOR

Her confession had set her free—

But it had also changed her.

She could never go back

to who she was before.

Her phone VIBRATES on the nightstand.

She picks it up.

TEXT - EMMA:

I think you should see this.
(Attached: a single
photo.)

Rachel taps it open.

Her breath catches.

A wall. A bedroom wall.

Two tally marks.

Rachel's face goes pale.

She types quickly.

TEXT - RACHEL:

Whose house is this?

The reply comes fast.

TEXT - EMMA:

A new family just moved in.

Rachel lowers the phone slowly.

Her fingers tighten around it.

NARRATOR

The cycle had started again. Marky
Mark had chosen his next victim.

She stares at the screen, then whispers—

RACHEL

Chatham remembers.

FLASHBACK

YEAR: 1880

LOCATION: BENTHAM COURTHOUSE

INT. BENTHAM COURTHOUSE - NIGHT

A violent storm rages outside.

Thunder rattles the stained-glass windows of a candlelit courtroom packed with **grim townsfolk**.

At the bench, a gaunt **JUDGE (60s)** in a powdered wig reads aloud.

JUDGE

You are hereby sentenced to life
imprisonment—
Followed by death by hanging—
For the homicides of Thomas Griggs
and Clara Weller,
And for the heinous, unspeakable
crimes committed
against the people of Bentham.
May God have mercy on your soul.

AT THE CENTER OF THE COURTROOM STANDS
MARCUS ROOKE (LATE 30S) — HOLLOW-EYED,
SHACKLED.

He says nothing.

He simply stares forward.

Two guards seize him.

His chains **rattle** as they escort him into the shadows.

INT. PRISON CELL - VARIOUS DAYS - MONTAGE

— Marcus sits in silence, **carving tally marks** into the stone wall.

— Rats crawl across the floor.

— A meal tray slides through the door. Slop.

— Marcus eats. Carves. Watches. Never speaks.

— A fellow **cellmate** scribbles in a leather-bound **journal** by candlelight.

— The wall slowly fills with **hundreds of tallies**.

EXT. BENTHAM PRISON - NIGHT - 1885

Rain pours from a black sky.

A furious mob crowds the muddy street — torches lit, pitchforks raised.

CROWD (CHANTING)

Give us the Rooke!

(MORE)

CROWD (CONT'D)
Justice for Bentham!

INT. PRISON - SAME TIME

Two guards watch nervously from the gate.

GUARD #1
They're not going away.

GUARD #2
He's not worth dying for.

They unlock the gate.

EXT. PRISON GATE - NIGHT

Marcus Rooke is dragged out into the storm.

Soaked, bruised - but standing tall.

He does not resist.

EXT. OLD CHAPEL - NIGHT

The mob surrounds an **old wooden chapel** on a hill.

A makeshift **gallows** has been erected beneath the chapel's **stone cross**.

Marcus is led up the stairs. Forced to his knees.

A **hooded figure** throws a rope over the beam.

VILLAGER
Any last words?

Marcus lifts his head.

The rain streaks down his face.

His voice is low. Calm. Measured.

MARCUS ROOKE
You counted my sins...
Now they shall be counted against
you.

A beat.

SNAP.
The rope pulls tight.

His body drops.

The storm howls.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. MODERN-DAY BEDROOM - NIGHT

A wall.

Burned.

TALLY MARKS.

Rachel stands frozen before them.

Silent.

NARRATOR

This wasn't just a killer...

It was a curse.

INT. DINGY MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

Sanchez — nicknamed *The Roach* — sits slouched in a faded armchair, nursing a glass of whisky.

The TV glows silently in the corner.

From the **bathroom mirror**, a woman adjusts her hair.

WOMAN (O.S.)

What should we do for dinner?

Roach scoffs, not even turning around.

ROACH

Dinner?

We're not having dinner together.

Suddenly—

The lights flicker.

The air drops cold.

A sharp **SCRATCHING** echoes from the walls.

TALLY MARKS begin carving themselves into the motel paint.

WOMAN (O.S.)

What the hell is that—

A **SCREAM** from the bathroom.

INT. BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

She stares into the mirror.

Marky Mark EMERGES, boots soaked in **mud**, trailing **wet footprints** behind him.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - CONTINUOUS

ROACH stumbles to his feet.

He reaches for a handgun on the nightstand—hands trembling.

Too late.

Marky Mark grabs the gun—

—and shoves the barrel **into Roach's mouth.**

BLAM.

Roach **chokes**. Gurgles. Collapses. Dead.

INT. BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

The woman turns, eyes wide—

She slams the door.

She backs up, trembling—

Turns—

He's already there.

Marky Mark reaches forward.

His hand **phases through her forehead—**

Like smoke.

With surgical stillness, he **pulls out her brain**, whole and glistening.

She drops like a puppet cut from its strings.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The door bursts open.

The **MOTEL MANAGER** stumbles in—

Then FREEZES.

Blood covers the room.

Marky Mark stands in the center.

He raises both arms.

Behind him—

The full-length mirror reflects HELL—

Flames. Chains. Screams. Torment.

And in Marky Mark's **hollow, burning eyes—**

It burns brighter.

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. MOTEL PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Police lights flash across the wet pavement.

Wind kicks up yellow **caution tape**, flapping in the cold.

Rachel pulls up. Steps out of her cruiser.

She walks toward the building, ducking under the tape.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

The room is a bloodbath.

Two bodies lie still.

Eyes burned shut, skin scorched and sealed.

On each **eyelid — two tally marks**, seared deep like **ritual scars**.

Rachel stares, her breath catching.

RACHEL

I've never seen carnage like this.

A nearby **OFFICER**, pale and shaken, shakes his head.

OFFICER

Neither have I.

Rachel swallows hard.

She pulls out her phone.

Dials EMMA.

(MORE)

OFFICER (CONT'D)
(RING. RING.)
(VOICEMAIL.)

She dials again.
(Straight to voicemail.)

Rachel lowers the phone slowly, eyes narrowing.

NARRATOR
The reckoning wasn't over. It had
only just begun.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. EMMA'S HOUSE - NIGHT

EMMA stands frozen in the living room.

Face pale.

Lips trembling.

She stares directly into the **eyes of Marky Mark**.

He says nothing.

He doesn't have to.

NARRATOR
What she saw in his gaze was
enough— A vision of hell so
horrifying
it turned her to stone.

EXT. EMMA'S STREET - NIGHT

Rachel's cruiser pulls into the driveway.

She jumps out, weapon drawn, racing toward the door.

INT. EMMA'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The door BURSTS OPEN.

Rachel storms in, scanning—

She freezes.

EMMA lies on the floor.

Lifeless.

Her eyes are scorched shut.

Two tally marks burned into each eyelid.

On the wall behind her—

Written in something **dark and wet:**

MARKY MARK WAS HERE

Rachel trembles.

She lifts her phone.

Dials.

RACHEL

Sir... we've got a problem.

CLICK.

The line cuts out.

SLAM.

The front door swings shut behind her.

Rachel whirls, weapon raised—

No one's there.

Silence.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. BENTHAM POLICE STATION - EVIDENCE LOCKER - NIGHT

Fluorescents buzz overhead.

MIKE HEATH — jittery, sweaty — rifles through sealed evidence bags.

NARRATOR

A known pilferer and coke fiend...
Mike had a system: Just enough to
keep the numbers off by a hair.

He finds a small **plastic bag of cocaine.**

Rips it open. Dips a trembling finger.

Tastes it.

SCRATCH.

Mike freezes.

The lights flicker.

A cold breath curls across the back of his neck.

He turns—

MARKY MARK stands silently behind him.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)
Confess... or die.

Mike stumbles backward, eyes wide.

Marky Mark steps forward.

Grabs the bag.

SLAMS it into Mike's mouth—crushing it against his face.

White powder explodes across the room like a blizzard.

Mike **chokes**, gags, collapses—convulsing.

INT. EVIDENCE LOCKER - MOMENTS LATER

The **POLICE CHIEF** storms in.

POLICE CHIEF
Mike? What the hell is—

He stops cold.

Too late.

Marky Mark lunges—

His **arm pierces the chief's chest**, clean through.

Bone crunches.

With a grotesque **twist**, he rips out the **still-beating heart**.

The chief stands for a beat—shocked—then drops to his knees, convulsing.

THUD.
He hits the ground.

Marky Mark kneels over him.

Gently, he **closes the chief's eyes**—

HISSSSS.
Smoke rises as the lids **burn shut**,
tally marks **searing into the flesh**.

The room fills with the stench of **scorched meat**.

Silence.

Marky Mark fades into the shadows.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. SUBURBAN LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

A modest home.

A **family of four** sits on the couch—TV murmuring softly.

Dinner plates rest on their laps.

The father flips channels. The mother sips wine.

The **youngest child** picks at broccoli with a plastic fork.

Suddenly—

The TV flickers.

Signal distortion. Audio fuzz.

Then—**BLACK SCREEN.**

A message appears.

GLOWING RED LETTERS on a pitch-black background:

CONFESS OR DIE.

Silence.

The family stares at the screen, paralyzed.

The youngest child begins to **cry**.

INT. LOCAL NEWS STATION - MAKEUP ROOM - SAME TIME

SUSAN (40S), THE EVENING ANCHOR, SITS
IN THE MAKEUP CHAIR.

She adjusts her foundation under the soft glow of **vanity bulbs**.

She leans closer to the mirror—

Suddenly, the **mirror ripples** like disturbed water.

From its depths—

A **pale hand**, slick with **black sludge**, emerges silently.

It wraps around her throat.

Susan GASPS—her compact clatters to the floor.

Before she can scream—

She's yanked into the mirror.

Her body disappears.

The glass calms.

Still.

Quiet.

The chair sits empty.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MEGA-CHURCH - REVEREND MATTHEW SINCLAIR'S OFFICE -
NIGHT

A gold-plated cross hangs over the mahogany desk.

Stacks of donation envelopes lie scattered, many of them
stuffed with cash.

REVEREND MATTHEW SINCLAIR, LATE 50S, A
TELEVANGELIST WITH A GOLDEN SMILE AND
A ROTTING SOUL, SITS IN HIS LEATHER
CHAIR, COUNTING MONEY.

His Rolex glints in the dim candlelight.

A gust of wind blows through the office.

He pauses.

A faint scratching sound emerges from the walls.

Sinclair's breath hitches.

He turns toward the darkened hallway.

The candle flames flicker wildly.

Then—a voice.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)
Confess... or die.

The lights cut out.

Darkness floods the room.

A figure looms in the candlelight—

Marky Mark emerges from the shadows.

Sinclair falls to his knees.

SINCLAIR

No, please... I've done nothing
wrong.

Marky Mark tilts his head.

The walls crack and split—tally marks scratching into the
paint.

The cross above the desk slowly turns upside down.

Sinclair starts hyperventilating.

He clutches his chest.

Marky Mark steps closer.

Sinclair tries to crawl away, but his legs won't move.

His eyes burn.

Smoke rises from his eyelids—two marks searing into his
flesh.

Sinclair lets out a silent scream.

Marky Mark leans down, his masked face inches from
Sinclair's.

With one swift motion, he slams the holy book shut—on
Sinclair's throat.

BONE CRUNCHES.

Sinclair collapses, twitching.

The candlelight dies.

FADE TO BLACK.

MONTAGE SEQUENCE

MUSIC CUE: "AFTER DARK" by Mr.Kitty
plays throughout.

INT. DARK BASEMENT - NIGHT

A man in a priest's collar types aggressively at a computer.

He turns.

SCRATCH.

The wall behind him bleeds tally marks.

Marky Mark rises from the shadows.

CUT TO:

EXT. LUXURY CONDO - NIGHT

A tech CEO drinks wine on a high-rise balcony.

She turns toward the patio door—

In the reflection—**he's inside.**

Glass shatters.

SCREAM. Blood smears the windows.

CUT TO:

INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - NIGHT

Lockers rattle.

A girl scrolls through hateful messages on her phone.

Behind her, **two marks burn into the locker door.**

She turns.

He's there.

CUT TO:

INT. RESTAURANT KITCHEN - NIGHT

A chef snorts cocaine in a walk-in freezer.

The lights flicker.

His reflection in the steel door doesn't move.

Suddenly, Marky Mark is behind him—**slashes his throat with a jagged ice chip.**

CUT TO:

INT. CHURCH CONFESSIONAL - NIGHT

A woman kneels.

WOMAN
Forgive me, Father, for I have
sinned—

The priest's voice changes.

MARKY MARK (V.O.)
Confess... or die.

The curtain parts.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED THEATER - NIGHT

A wannabe influencer livestreams a ghost hunt.

He turns his phone to a mirror—

Marky Mark is behind him.

The stream glitches—static.

Blood on the lens.

CUT TO:

INT. PRISON SHOWER - NIGHT

A corrupt guard sings off-key.

SCRATCH.
Steam fills the air.

He slips—lands hard.

Marky Mark steps into frame—**burns marks into his back** with
the end of a hot pipe.

CUT TO:

INT. HOTEL ROOM - NIGHT

A politician lies in bed, watching an affair video of
himself.

The screen goes black.

TWO WORDS APPEAR: **CONFESS OR DIE**
He gets up—door opens on its own.

Too late.

CUT TO:

EXT. GAS STATION - NIGHT

A clerk sees tally marks carved into the pumps.

He turns—his shadow doesn't follow.

Marky Mark bursts from the cooler.

Glass explodes. Lights go red.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBWAY CAR - MOVING - NIGHT

A lone man rides in silence.

Graffiti on the window changes—"YOU'RE NEXT."

He pounds on the doors.

They won't open.

Marky Mark sits beside him.

The lights go out.

Screams echo.

FADE OUT:

MUSIC ENDS.

EXT. CITY HALL - DAY

Press cameras FLASH.

The MAYOR (50s) stands at the podium, sweat beading under the bright lights.

Crowds of **reporters** and **city staff** murmur restlessly.

MAYOR

As you all know...

These murders have grown more violent.

And more specific.

He swallows hard.

MAYOR (CONT'D)

I've decided to resign—effective immediately.

The deputy mayor will assume leadership.

The crowd stirs.

Flashes light up his face like lightning.

MAYOR (CONT'D)
My sins are many.

And if the rumors are true...

I fear I'm only putting this city in more danger.

Among the crowd—

RACHEL watches silently, from behind a barricade.

She reaches into her coat.

Pulls out a **tattered leather journal**.

Her fingers flip to a page.

A name, scrawled in faded ink:

James Bell, 1883.

EXT. BENTHAM CEMETERY - NIGHT

A storm builds.

Winds howl through rows of fresh graves.

Rain slicks the earth.

Rachel moves through the newer section—then deeper, into the **older part**.

Moss-covered stones lean like **crooked teeth** in the dark.

She stops.

Before her: **Two massive headstones.**

JAMES BELL
MARCUS ROOKE

Thunder rumbles.

Lightning flashes.

A FIGURE stands at the edge of the graves.

Marky Mark.

A flaming torch in hand.

His **eyes locked on Rachel.**

Rachel turns—

RUNS.

Marky Mark gives chase.

He **glides above the ground**, silent, unnatural.

EXT. CEMETERY - CARETAKER'S SHED - NIGHT

Rachel sprints across the field.

She spots a decrepit **washroom building**, door slightly ajar.

She dives inside—

INT. WASHROOM - NIGHT

She slams the door.

Breathing ragged. Heart hammering.

Outside—thunder CRACKS.

The **lights flicker—**

Then die.

The door creaks open.

Marky Mark enters.

Torch in hand.

Eyes burning.

Rachel SCREAMS.

COLLAPSES.

The room is swallowed by **darkness.**

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. DARK VOID - UNKNOWN

Rachel drifts.

Flashes of **fire.**

Screaming.

Writhing bodies.

A vision of hell.

INT. CEMETERY WASHROOM - NIGHT

Rachel GASPS AWAKE.

Soaked in sweat. Shaking.

A **JANITOR (60s)** crouches beside her, holding a **flashlight**.

JANITOR
Miss? Are you okay?

Rachel flinches—blinks hard, unsure if she's still dreaming.

RACHEL
I—I think so.

JANITOR
Want me to call someone?

She slowly shakes her head. Dizzy. Pale.

RACHEL
No ambulance.

Just... help me up.

He offers his hand.

She takes it.

Stands—**trembling**.

She checks herself.

Sidearm—gone.

Phone—missing.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
I've got to get out of here.

She stumbles toward the door, wind howling outside.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. CITY PERIMETER - NIGHT

Rain **hammers the windshield** as Rachel approaches her parked cruiser.

Lightning flashes. Wind roars.

She moves with purpose—soaked, exhausted.

Ahead, **THE MAYOR** steps into view.

His suit clings to his body. His eyes are tired. Hollow.
Desperate.

MAYOR
Are you staying?
We could use your help.

Rachel doesn't stop.

She brushes past him.

Opens the cruiser door.

Slides behind the wheel.

RACHEL
You people...
Are on your own.

The **engine roars to life.**

She slams the door.

Red taillights vanish into the storm.

The mayor stands in silence.

Soaked.

Helpless.

EXT. OPEN ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Rachel's cruiser disappears into the night.

Behind her—

The city of Bentham fades.

Just shadows and storm clouds.

EXT. CEMETERY - NIGHT

Lightning CRACKS across the sky.

Illuminating—

MARKY MARK.
He stands silhouetted among the
graves.

The **torch in his hand** blazes unnaturally bright.

Smoke **curls** around him like tendrils.

He **stares straight** at us.

Unmoving.

CUT TO BLACK.

ON SCREEN - BLOOD-RED TEXT:
(**EVERY LIE LEAVES A
MARK...**)

FADE TO BLACK.

CREDITS ROLL.